

AI adoption and system integration by business size

Evidence from the UK Business Data Survey 2026

PRIVATE REPORT 02 - NOT FOR PUBLICATION

D-018 approved evidence brief

Executive summary

This report presents two related but distinct measures: reported AI use among all businesses, and system integration among businesses already using AI. The measures use different denominators and are not combined mathematically.

1. Reported AI use

Denominator: all businesses in each size group

Micro	37.4%
Small	50.8%
Medium	57.1%
Large*	78.2%

* Large businesses are a reference benchmark.

2. System integration

Denominator: businesses already using AI

Micro	26.9%
Small	31.5%
Medium	30.9%
Large*	57.4%

* Large businesses are a reference benchmark.

How to read the evidence

Table 42 describes the breadth of reported AI use across all businesses. Table 48 describes integration depth only within the survey's AI-user population. The Table 48 percentages are not shares of all businesses and this report does not estimate a conversion funnel.

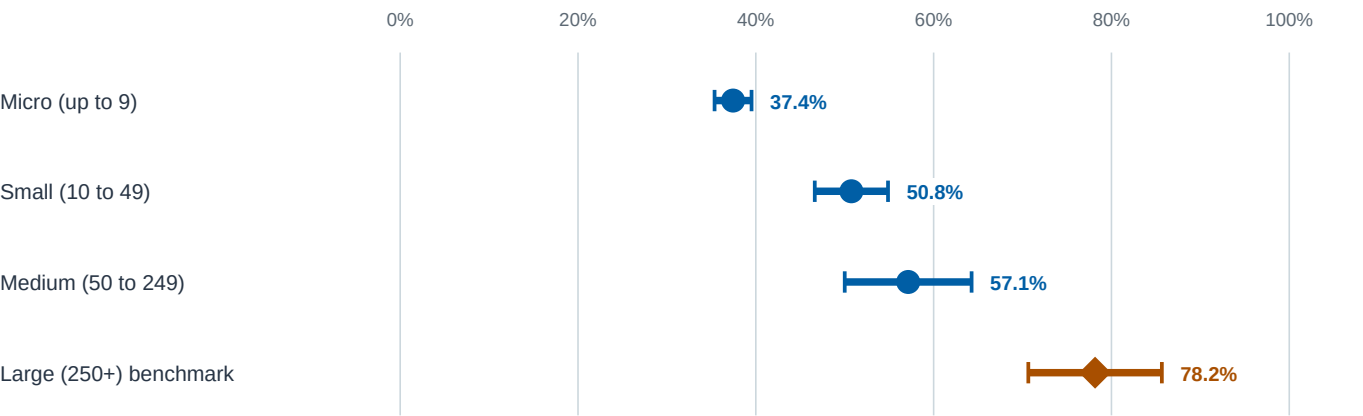
Headline insights

- Reported AI use rises across the published size-group point estimates.
- Among AI users, small and medium integration estimates are similar; the large benchmark is higher.
- The evidence is descriptive and does not establish significance, causation, readiness, value or service demand.

Reported AI use among all businesses

DENOMINATOR

All UK businesses within each published business-size category.



Evidence table

Published size group	Estimate	95% interval	Base
Micro, up to 9 employees	37.4%	35.4% to 39.5%	2,500
Small, 10 to 49 employees	50.8%	46.6% to 54.9%	680
Medium, 50 to 249 employees	57.1%	50.0% to 64.3%	220
Large, 250 or more employees*	78.2%	70.7% to 85.7%	130

* Large businesses are a reference benchmark.

Interpretation

The point estimates rise across the published business-size groups. This is a descriptive pattern and the large-business value is a reference benchmark outside the primary SME scope.

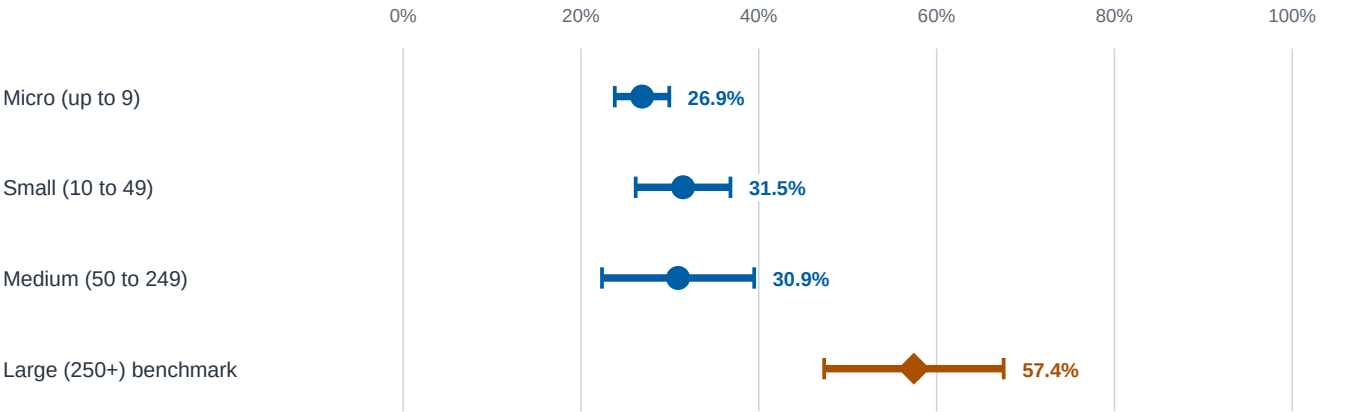
SOURCE AND BOUNDARY

DSIT, UK Business Data Survey 2026, Table 42. No formal significance or causal claim. Bases are rounded unweighted samples, not business counts.

System integration among businesses already using AI

DENOMINATOR

UK businesses in each size group that report using AI technologies. These are not percentages of all UK businesses.



Evidence table

Published size group	Estimate	95% interval	Base
Micro, up to 9 employees	26.9%	23.8% to 29.9%	960
Small, 10 to 49 employees	31.5%	26.1% to 36.8%	350
Medium, 50 to 249 employees	30.9%	22.4% to 39.5%	130
Large, 250 or more employees*	57.4%	47.4% to 67.5%	100

* Large businesses are a reference benchmark.

Interpretation

Among AI-using businesses, the large-business benchmark has a higher point estimate than the three SME groups. The small and medium point estimates are similar. This is descriptive, not a formal test.

SOURCE AND BOUNDARY

DSIT, UK Business Data Survey 2026, Table 48. Do not convert to an all-business integration rate or combine arithmetically with Table 42. No significance or causal claim.

What the evidence supports - and what it does not

How the measures fit together

ADOPTION BREADTH

Table 42 estimates reported AI use among all businesses in each published size group.

INTEGRATION DEPTH

Table 48 estimates system integration only among businesses in the size group that already report AI use.

Evidence boundaries

Supported descriptive wording

- Point estimates vary by published business size.
- Reported AI-use estimates rise across the size groups.
- Among AI users, small and medium integration estimates are similar.
- Large businesses remain a separate benchmark.

Not supported by this evidence

- Formal significance or causal claims.
- An all-business integration rate or conversion funnel.
- Readiness, productivity, ROI or intervention effectiveness.
- Counts of UK businesses or evidence of service demand.

Source and method

Source: Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, UK Business Data Survey 2026. Dataset version: 18 June 2026. Fieldwork: 10 October 2025 to 28 January 2026. Estimates are weighted percentages with supplied 95% confidence limits. Bases are rounded unweighted respondent counts, not counts of UK businesses.

Evidence trail

F-001: D-010 result, D-011 comparison method, D-012 chart and D-013 first brief. F-002: D-014 scope, D-015 processed snapshot, D-016 result and D-017 chart. Combined brief: D-018.

INTERNAL REVIEW BOUNDARY

This private report is for owner review. External sharing and publication remain unapproved.